



The basilica of St. Peter's in the Vatican City, Rome, is the focus of devotion for millions of Catholics worldwide. The original was destroyed in the early 16th century. Its replacement, which is topped by a magnificent dome designed by Michelangelo, took over a century to build.

**Faiths spread throughout the world, and regional changes occurred where some religions were adopted by new cultures.**

#### UNIVERSAL TEACHINGS

The guru—a revered teacher of spiritual matters—became central to Hinduism. New Hindu schools have arisen, aiming to make its thought more universal. A celebrated modernist, Sri Ramakrishna (1836–86) taught the **essential unity of all religions** and the Ramakrishna Mission spread far beyond India.

#### DISPERSION

The Jewish diaspora continued, and by the middle ages France and Spain had become two of its most important centers. During the 19th century an exodus of Jews took place from Russia and Poland, and in the Nazi holocaust **400–01** >> many of the old European communities were **virtually annihilated**. In 1947 the **modern state of Israel 414–15** >> was born, annexed from the indigenous population of Palestinians. Today, the main focus of diaspora Judaism is the United States.

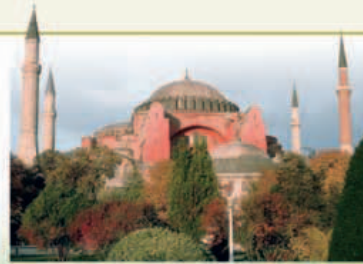
#### REGIONAL DIFFERENCES

Buddhism evolved into **various regional forms** as its influence extended through Central and Southeast Asia, China, Japan, and most recently, the West.

#### GREAT CHANGES

By the 11th century, Christianity had split into two, the western Church under the papacy in Rome and the eastern Orthodox Church. In the 16th century it split again when **challenges to papal authority** resulted in the Reformation **256–59** >>.

The Hagia Sofia in Istanbul, Turkey, is a magnificent example of Byzantine architecture. It was dedicated as a church by the Roman emperor Justinian I in 537 CE, then in 1453 CE was converted into a mosque. In 1935 it was turned into the Ayasofya Museum.



Mount Kailas, on the border between Tibet and Nepal, is a holy place for Buddhists and Hindus alike. Pilgrims trek up the Humla valley to walk around the mountain, but no one has ever climbed its slopes.



#### Spreading the faith

This map charts the principal routes along which the faiths of Hinduism, Buddhism, and Christianity expanded during their early development, including smaller branches on which more isolated outposts arose. In most instances the newly introduced religion was not the only faith practiced in the region, but in many areas it became the dominant one.

The Church of St. George at Lalibela is one of eleven churches carved from volcanic rock high in Ethiopia's Amhara Mountains. The 13th-century church is a place of Christian pilgrimage and has been declared a world heritage site.



The vast Potola Palace that towers above Lhasa, Tibet, dates from 1645. Once the seat of the Tibetan government, it houses the tombs of past Dalai Lamas, the spiritual leaders of Tibetan Buddhists, and is a major pilgrimage destination.



The city of Varanasi in the Indian state of Uttar Pradesh is one of the holiest pilgrimage sites for Hindus, who come to bathe in the sacred waters of the Ganges and to cremate the dead.



The great Buddhist shrine at Borobudur, Java, is topped with bell-shaped stupas containing images of Buddha. The temple complex was built in the 8th century.

